

Vula Careers — Marketing Plan

Two audiences, two very different playbooks: learners (B2C, free, viral) and sponsors (B2B, relationship-driven, slow).

1. Positioning & Messaging

One-line positioning: *"Your free career guide, right inside WhatsApp — open your future in 5 minutes."*

Core message pillars (already reflected in the marketing site — keep consistent everywhere): 1. **Free, forever** — no cost, no catch, no app. 2. **Fast** — 5 minutes, tappable, pause-and-resume. 3. **Actionable** — exact subjects and marks needed, not vague personality-type fluff. 4. **Private** — POPIA-compliant, no data sold, learner controls their own information (DELETE/STOP anytime). 5. **(For sponsors)** — reach the right prospective students by interest and geography, without buying a database.

2. Audience 1: Learners (B2C acquisition)

Who

Grade 10–12 learners across South Africa, phone-first, data-conscious, WhatsApp-native. Parents, Life Orientation (LO) teachers and school counsellors are key *influencers* even though the learner is the end user.

Channels, ranked by expected cost-efficiency

1. **WhatsApp referral / word-of-mouth loop** — the single highest-leverage channel. After a learner completes their report, prompt them to share Vula with 2–3 classmates ("this helped you — who else needs it?"). Near-zero marginal cost, and WhatsApp is inherently a sharing-native platform.
2. **School partnerships** — approach LO teachers, school career counsellors (where they exist) and principals directly. Offer Vula as a free classroom activity ("get your whole Grade 10 class their career profile in one lesson"). This is the highest-trust, highest-conversion channel and doubles as a pipeline into schools that later matter for sponsor credibility ("used in X schools").
3. **Social media (organic)** — TikTok and Instagram are where SA teens actually are. Short, relatable content: "POV: you're choosing subjects and have no idea what you want to be," result reveals, "did you know Grade 10 subjects lock this in" hooks. Youth-relevant creators/micro-influencers in the SA education/edutainment space can amplify at low cost.
4. **Community & youth organisations** — churches, youth groups, NPOs already working with the target age group (e.g. bursary/mentorship NGOs) are a trusted distribution channel and often actively looking for free tools to hand to the learners they serve.
5. **Paid acquisition (later, once unit economics from sponsors justify it)** — Meta/TikTok ads targeting Grade 10–12-aged users' parents/older siblings, geo-targeted to launch cities. Hold off until

sponsor revenue can fund learner acquisition cost, since learners themselves generate zero direct revenue.

Launch sequencing

- **Phase 1 (Cape Town):** concentrate all school-partnership and local social content here first, matching the initial sponsor city focus — a Cape Town learner should already see real sponsor options, which makes the product feel complete rather than empty.
- **Phase 2:** expand to Johannesburg/Pretoria (largest combined learner population), then Durban.
- **Phase 3:** national rollout once sponsor coverage exists in enough cities that "Other/National" isn't doing most of the work.

Content calendar themes (rotate weekly once active)

- Myth-busting ("You don't need to know your career at 15 — but you do need the right subjects")
- Real learner report snapshots (with consent, anonymised)
- "Did you know" facts about SA qualification pathways (TVET vs university vs learnership)
- Parent-facing content (a parent is often the one who needs convincing this is legitimate and safe)

3. Audience 2: Sponsors (B2B acquisition)

Who

Three sub-segments, each needing a different pitch: 1. **University/college marketing & student-recruitment offices** — care about applicant pipeline and brand awareness among prospective students. 2. **Corporate CSI / Skills Development / bursary programme owners** — care about B-BBEE scorecard points, ESG reporting, and pipeline into their own bursary/learnership programmes. 3. **TVET colleges & SETAs** — care about awareness of artisan/trade pathways, which are chronically under-marketed relative to university routes.

The pitch (adapt per segment)

- **To universities/colleges:** "Reach prospective students who match your programmes' ideal profile, in the cities you recruit from, before they've locked in their subject choices or made up their mind — at a fraction of the cost of an open day or print campaign."
- **To corporates:** "Your Skills Development / CSI budget can fund awareness of your bursary or learnership programme among exactly the learners whose interests fit it — measurable, low-cost, and safely POPIA-compliant since we never hand over personal data."
- **To TVET colleges/SETAs:** "Most learners default to 'university or nothing' because no one tells them about artisan and trade pathways early enough. Vula surfaces TVET options to learners whose profile (hands-on, practical) actually fits them."

Channels for sponsor acquisition

1. **Direct outreach** — this is a relationship sale; cold email/LinkedIn to the right department (see SPONSORSHIP_TARGETS.md) followed by a short deck + live demo of the WhatsApp flow is the core motion.
2. **Founding Sponsor offer** — discounted first-year pricing for the first 5–10 sponsors in exchange for a case study/testimonial and permission to use their logo on the marketing site once real usage data exists. This solves the classic "no one wants to be first" problem.
3. **CSI/SED conferences and forums** — SA has an active CSI/ESG events circuit (Trialogue publishes an annual CSI Handbook and runs related events) — good for warm intros to corporate CSI budget owners.
4. **SETA engagement** — SETAs run stakeholder forums for skills-pipeline initiatives; worth registering Vula as a relevant awareness partner where applicable.
5. **Case studies once live** — nothing sells the next sponsor like "here's the engagement data from your peer institution's course over the last quarter."

Sales collateral to produce

- A one-page sponsor pitch deck (problem, how Vula works, what a sponsor gets, pricing tiers, how to get started) — reuse the language in BUSINESS_PLAN.md §4.
- A short screen-recording or live demo script of the WhatsApp flow ending in "Sponsored option near you."
- A simple onboarding form/checklist for a new sponsor (institution details, course details, city, RIASEC fit) that maps directly onto the admin Sponsors page fields.

4. KPIs to track

Learner side: completed assessments/week, WhatsApp share/referral rate, city distribution of learners (to prioritise where sponsors are most needed), PDF report open rate.

Sponsor side: number of active sponsors, sponsor revenue MRR, "sponsored option" impression count per career-detail view, sponsor renewal rate, cost of sponsor acquisition (time-to-close is the real cost here, not ad spend).

5. 90-Day Plan

Weeks	Focus
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1–2	Finish production WhatsApp approval; sign 2–3 Founding Sponsors in Cape Town (start with the most agile — private colleges/TVET — while university procurement cycles run in parallel)
3–6	School-partnership outreach in Cape Town; launch organic social content; onboard signed sponsors into the admin Sponsors page
7–10	Expand sponsor outreach to Johannesburg/Pretoria; begin collecting first usage case-study data from Cape Town sponsors
11–13	Use Cape Town case study to accelerate Johannesburg/Pretoria sponsor conversations; evaluate whether paid learner-acquisition makes sense given sponsor revenue to date